

The paediatric programme, for specialists.

A multidisciplinary medical–psychological intervention for paediatric gut–brain disorders, delivered through targeted caregiver education.

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Overview

A structured, evidence-informed workshop series supporting children and adolescents with disorders of gut–brain interaction through targeted caregiver education and multidisciplinary intervention. The programme integrates neurogastroenterology, clinical psychology and behavioural medicine, giving caregivers a cohesive framework for understanding and responding to gut–brain symptoms in young people. It complements specialist medical care — particularly for families navigating persistent symptoms, functional disruption, or heightened distress despite appropriate investigation and reassurance.

Indications for referral

- IBS, functional or centrally mediated abdominal pain, functional dyspepsia, nausea syndromes.
- Bloating, constipation, diarrhoea, mixed bowel symptoms, or motility-related symptoms as clinically indicated.
- Autonomically driven or stress-sensitive GI symptoms; persistent symptoms despite normal investigations.
- School refusal, fatigue, reduced participation, or functional impairment linked to symptoms.
- Anxiety, symptom hypervigilance, avoidance patterns, or reassurance-seeking within the family system.

Appropriate at any stage — early presentation, post-investigation, long-standing or complex cases, pre- or post-specialist review.

Clinical rationale

Paediatric DGBIs reflect neurophysiological dysregulation of the gut–brain axis, not structural pathology alone. Persistence and escalation are shaped by autonomic activation, stress sensitivity and emotional reactivity, cognitive threat appraisal and symptom focus, developmental executive functioning limitations, avoidance cycles across food, school, movement and social participation, caregiver responses and family accommodation patterns, and disrupted routines. The programme strengthens recovery conditions in the home environment through caregiver understanding, regulation and skill-building.

VALUE TO YOUR PRACTICE

Families entering or returning to specialist care are typically better informed, more regulated, and more able to implement behavioural plans — supporting improved efficiency and clinician satisfaction.

- Reduces repeat reassurance-based consultations and low-yield investigations.
- Increases caregiver understanding of gut–brain mechanisms and functional recovery.
- Improves readiness for specialist review through better family regulation and expectations.
- Provides early-intervention tools that reduce escalation, avoidance, and chronic disability trajectories.

Model of care — The Executive Frame™

Emotional intelligence

Caregiver regulation and nervous system stabilisation to reduce stress-related gut reactivity.

Executive functioning

Routines, pacing, consistency, and graded return to school, movement, eating and daily activities.

Self-determination

Autonomy, competence and connection — motivation and long-term behaviour change.

Programme content

- Gut–brain and neurogastroenterology education.
- Nervous system stabilisation and emotional regulation tools.
- Symptom reframing and cognitive flexibility strategies.
- Behavioural medicine — pacing, graded exposure, re-engagement, habit support.
- Caregiver response training to reduce reassurance loops and accommodation.
- Values-based goals and sustainable microsteps for family routines.

REFERRAL & DELIVERY	
Format	Half-day caregiver workshops, face-to-face · Auckland and Christchurch
Suits	Triage support, waitlist care, post-investigation recovery planning
Cost	\$350 per person · \$500 for two caregivers
Christchurch	Saturday 21 February · 1:00pm–4:00pm
Auckland	Tuesday 3 February · 9:00am–12:00pm
Referral	Direct referral · confirmed diagnosis not required · rosec@macmurray.co.nz